

Greek magic and myth

The myths retold in Homer's epics, the *Iliad* and *Odyssey*, and in tragic plays, reflect the ancient Greeks' fascination with magic. The stories include the full range of magic, from prophecies and curses to sacrifices, animal and human. For example, one tells how at the start of the Trojan War Iphigenia, daughter of King Agamemnon, was sacrificed to the goddess Artemis. Dark magic plays a key role in these tales, too. Odysseus, for instance, held a necromantic rite by slaughtering a black ram in order to attract the ghosts of the dead with whom he wished to commune. Another hero, Orpheus, could charm animals with his lyre, a skill he used to lull Cerberus, the triple-headed hell-hound that guarded the gates of Hades (the underworld), to sleep, in an unsuccessful attempt to rescue his dead wife, Eurydice.

Even more potent were the witches, such as Circe, daughter of the sun god Helios, who turned Odysseus's companions into pigs by feeding them enchanted cheese. Odysseus only escaped their fate through counter-magic. Most skilled and terrible of all was Medea. Her feats included giving her future husband, Jason, a magic lotion to shield him from fire-breathing bulls (guardians of the magical golden fleece); raising his father from the dead; and using enchanted fire to burn Creusa, for whom Jason abandoned her, to death. Dabbling in dark magic was known to have benefits but rarely ended well.

“I’ve bound my deceitful husband with the bonds of powerful oaths and curses.”

MEDEA, IN EURIPIDES' PLAY *MEDEA*, 431 BCE

